

A plain-English breakdown of a very unusual AI deal

Anthropic × SpaceX.

Anthropic is leasing an entire SpaceX data center to double the compute behind Claude — and the two companies floated something even stranger: data centers in orbit.

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READ TIME

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The 30-Second Version

In May 2026, Anthropic and SpaceX announced that Anthropic is leasing **all** of the AI compute capacity at SpaceX's Colossus 1 data center in Memphis — over 300 megawatts across more than 220,000 NVIDIA GPUs, coming online within weeks. The deal is worth roughly \$1.25 billion a month, reportedly totaling tens of billions of dollars over its multi-year term.

For Claude users, the practical upshot: doubled rate limits and no more peak-hour slowdowns on paid plans.

THE WILDER PART

SpaceX also owns xAI, maker of Grok — a direct Claude competitor. Months earlier, Elon Musk had publicly attacked Anthropic on X. Now his company is Anthropic's landlord.

Why Anthropic Needed This

Anthropic's usage grew explosively through 2026 — the kind of growth that breaks server capacity. The 5-hour rate limits, the "Claude is a bit busy" messages at peak hours — this is the fix. Renting an existing 220,000-GPU data center gets Anthropic online in weeks instead of the years it would take to build from scratch.

What Changed for Paid Claude Users

1

5-hour rate limits doubled

Same plan, same price — twice the usage window on Pro, Max, Team, and Enterprise.

2

Peak-hour throttling removed

No more slowdown during the 2–6pm window.

3

API token limits expanded

Tier 1 input and output limits on Opus grew substantially — workflows that felt too expensive last quarter may be affordable now.

All of it shipped automatically — no account changes needed.

The Genuinely Strange Part: Space

Buried in the announcement, both companies said they'd "expressed interest" in developing multiple gigawatts of AI compute capacity in orbit — a scale several times larger than the entire Colossus deal. The logic: space offers free cooling and 24/7 solar power, and SpaceX is the only company that can realistically launch that much hardware. This is years away, not a near-term product — but it signals where the infrastructure race is heading.

What to Do With This

1 Plan a longer session

You now have roughly double the headroom before hitting a rate limit.

2 Use Claude during peak hours without hesitation

The 2–6pm slowdown is gone for Pro and Max.

3 Retest API costs

If you build on the Claude API, workflows priced out last quarter may now pencil out.

Do This Today

01 If you've hit rate limits before, try the longer session you'd been avoiding.

02 If you build on the API, re-run your cost estimates.

— NeuraFlow Academy

Compiled from public reporting by CNBC, Data Center Dynamics, TechCrunch, Axios, Fortune, and Anthropic's own announcement, May 2026.